

The paradoxes of material constitution

February 3rd, 2004

The case

- At 10 am, I took a lump of modelling clay, and I shaped it with my fingers until it took on this statue-shape; at 11 am, I put it on the table.
- The sentences on the following slide seem to be inconsistent, so they can't all be true. But for each one, we have at least some inclination to think that it is true. Where are we going wrong?

The paradox

1. There is a statue-shaped statue on the table at 11am.
2. There is a statue-shaped lump of clay on the table at 11am.
3. If there is a statue on the table at 11am, it did not exist at 10am.
4. If there is a lump of clay on the table at 11am, it existed at 10am.
5. There is only one statue-shaped object on the table at 11am.

- These sentences seem to be inconsistent. Why?
- A general principle about counting: if some F is G, and some F is not G, then there are at least two Fs.
 - Applied to this case: 2 and 4 entail that some statue-shaped object on the table at 11am existed at 10am, and 1 and 3 entail that some statue-shaped object on the table at 11am didn't exist at 10 am; using the general principle about counting, we can conclude that there are at least two statue-shaped objects on the table at 11am.
- Intimately related to *Leibniz's Law* (if x is F, and $x = y$, then y is F).

Our options:

- Deny that these 5 sentences are in fact jointly inconsistent, despite initial appearances.
- Give up one or more of them.

Giving up 5

- An important argument for 5 appeals to the principle that *two material objects can't be in the same place at the same time*. If we give up 5, we must give up this principle too.
 - Indeed, if we give up 5 we will find ourselves pushed to the conclusion that it is *very common* for ordinary material objects to be in the same place at the same time.
 - EG: every tree is in the same place as some distinct “aggregate of wood molecules”.

Giving up 1.

(‘There is a statue on the table at 11am’)

- Surely if there are any statues at all, there is one on the table at 11am. So if we take this route, we will have to deny that there are any statues.
 - We may still maintain that there are *statue-shaped material objects* — e.g. lumps or quantities of clay.
- In fact, similar arguments arise for many other kinds of things: if we choose this route, we will find it hard to resist eliminativism about tables, cups, books, trees...

Giving up 3.

(‘If there is a statue on the table at 11am, it did not exist at 10am.’)

- Compare the following rather unconvincing ‘paradox’:

1a. There is a college professor delivering this lecture.

2a. There is a human being delivering this lecture.

3a. If there is a college professor delivering this lecture, it did not exist in 1990.

4a. If there is a human being delivering this lecture, it existed in 1990.

5a. There is only one thing delivering this lecture.

- Here, it is clear that we shouldn't accept 3b.
What's true is the following quite different claim:
 - If there is a college professor delivering this lecture, he wasn't a college professor in 1990.
- Someone who advocates giving up 3 might, analogously, claim that we find 3 tempting only because we confuse it with the following true claim:
 - If there is a statue on the table, it wasn't a statue at 10am.

But consider another case

- Suppose that at 3pm I will grow dissatisfied with my handiwork: I rip off its arms and cast them into the furnace. But at 4pm I will repent; I will make some new arms out of new clay, and reattach them to the mutilated torso.

- 1b. There is a statue-shaped statue on the table at 11am.
- 2b. There is a statue-shaped lump of clay on the table at 11am.
- 3b. If there is a statue on the table at 11am, it will exist at 4pm.
- 4b. If there is a lump of clay on the table at 11am, it will not exist at 4pm.
- 5b. There is only one statue-shaped object on the table at 11am.

- The move we made to “explain away” the plausibility of 3 won’t help us here. For if 3b is false, so is
 - If there is a statue on the table at 11am, it will be a statue at 4pm.